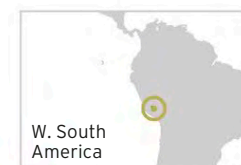


# Machu Picchu

*A magnificent Inca citadel and temple complex set high on a mountain ridge above the Urubamba River in Peru*



Founded by the Inca ruler Pachacuti Inca Yupanqui in the mid-15th century, Machu Picchu ("Old Hill") occupies a spectacular site in the High Andes of Peru, 50 miles (80 km) northwest of the Inca capital Cuzco. The fortified complex was primarily a sacred site dedicated to the Sun god Inti, as well as the administrative center for the region. It also enclosed a settlement of around 1,000 inhabitants (at its peak) and included accommodation for the aristocracy and a separate quarter of more modest dwellings to the south and east for the workers of the estate.

## Sun temple

The buildings of Machu Picchu are made from carefully cut blocks of granite in the characteristic Inca style, fitting together so precisely that they needed no mortar and arranged in irregular patterns to

withstand the effects of earthquakes. The finest of these are in the upper part of the citadel, which had religious and astronomical functions. Among them are the Temple of the Three Windows and the Torrén, or Temple of the Sun, which acted as a sort of observatory, with windows aligned with the Sun at the summer and winter solstices and with constellations important in Inca mythology.

## Lost and found

Thanks to its remote location, Machu Picchu escaped the plundering of the Spanish invasion and remained largely forgotten until the American explorer Hiram Bingham came across it in his search for the legendary "lost" Inca capital in 1911. In an ongoing program of restoration, more than a third of the city has now been renovated or reconstructed.



## △ BURIAL GOODS

Inca aristocracy were buried with valuable funerary goods, such as this golden figurine of a llama found at Machu Picchu.

## ▽ MOUNTAINTOP CITADEL

In both design and construction, the town and terraces of Machu Picchu integrate into the spectacular natural environment.

